

ELEPHANTINE STRIDES

After her emphatic win in Uttar Pradesh, the sky is the limit for Chief Minister Mayawati who has begun tours across the country, convinced that South Block will one day be hers

■ **By Subhash Mishra and Amarnath K. Menon**

UP aaj humari hai, kal Dilli ki baari hai! (UP is ours today. Tomorrow it will be Delhi's turn.)

The feisty chief minister of Uttar Pradesh has spent the last seven months working hard to turn this coronation slogan into a party manifesto. Ever since she captured the state in May last year, she has been campaigning furiously to convert her state victory into a pan-India phenomenon. Unfortunately for the Congress, her vote bank encroaches into the national party's political space.

The gloves are now officially off as both the Congress and BSP trade allegations. Mayawati is threatening to withdraw support from the UPA Government if the Congress does not accede to her demands. These include SPG cover for her and a Rs 80,000 crore financial package for the state. While the flash-point was Mayawati's demand for SPG cover, the confrontation really began the day she unveiled her prime ministerial ambitions. "I am extremely surprised by her statement that the UP Police is not good enough to look after her security," says Congress general secretary, Digvijay Singh. The chief minister in turn accuses the Congress of conspiring against her life by refusing her adequate security and shielding Atiq Ahmad, a former Samajwadi Party MP who is wanted in a murder investigation. "If she is so scared about her own security, how does she plan to look after the security of the common man," scoffs Jitin Prasad, a Congress MP from the state. But

Mayawati says it is the Congress which is feeling insecure. "The UP Police can look after me within the state. But I am a national leader and need to tour the entire country. Congress wants to limit me to UP alone," she says.

She could well be right. The Congress has been watching her forays beyond the Hindi heartland. Her recent rallies in Bangalore and Hyderabad drew adequate crowds to strengthen her role as a spoiler. She now says she will contest all the seats in the

FORAYS BEYOND BORDERS

■ **In elections held for the Punjab, Gujarat, Uttarakhand and Himachal assemblies last year, BSP gradually increased its vote percentage.**

■ **Having toured the south, Mayawati will cover the entire country by March.**

Karnataka polls, telling a 30,000-strong crowd in Bangalore, "BSP is looking to this state as a gateway to the south." In Andhra Pradesh, her state unit was keen on a tie-up with Chiranjeevi, but Mayawati dismissed this saying, "Film stars do no social service. They only sing and dance." This led to protest from the leaders of the Telugu tinsel town but Mayawati isn't perturbed. She is confident that her promises of statehood for Telangana and Dalit reservation will woo the votes.

Congress scion Rahul Gandhi has also upped the confrontation stakes. Unlike his mother, who hoped for a seat adjustment with Mayawati in 2004 (see

interview), Rahul harbours no such hopes. His Uttar Pradesh campaign last year was strident against both Mulayam Singh Yadav and Mayawati.

The decision on whether to withdraw the support of her 18 MPs from UPA will be taken after Mayawati cuts her 52nd birthday cake on January 15. Fuelled by ambition, she is in a combative mode, busy touring all of India, from the faraway south and also closer home to break the Noida jinx that unseats chief ministers soon after their visits. But Mayawati is ready to be unseated as she firmly believes her next stop is the prime minister's chair. No wonder the Congress is worried. ■

